ACC-02 · Account Naming, UPN & Identifier Standard

What every class of account is called, and how departmental access for temporary workers is structured — presented as Option A and Option B pending decision.

Field	Value
Document ID	ACC-02
Version	1.0 · Known Good edition, by Kevin Zelman
Catalogue domain	B. Account Usage
Operating tier	Tier 3 — Expert Services (“the attic”, the Tier 3 escalation address). Identity architecture is Tier 3 work. Tier 4 owns this document.
Review cycle	Annually, and whenever a new department requests temporary-worker access.
Decision status	Section 4 presents two options. Section 5 recommends Option B and gives the reasons in full.

1. Purpose

This standard states what each class of account is called, so that a name carries reliable information about what the account is and IT stops making the decision one request at a time.

Most of that is uncontroversial and is settled in section 3. One part usually is not. The common trigger is a request to extend an existing departmental temporary-worker convention, a second account with a departmental suffix, to yet another department, while people inside IT still disagree with the convention itself.

> **Why this document does not simply pick one**
>
> A convention that keeps being extended while it is still contested inside IT is the situation a standard exists to end, and it cannot be ended by IT quietly choosing: the departments already on the current pattern would see a change in how their temporary workers sign in.
>
> So section 4 sets out both conventions in full and section 5 makes a recommendation with reasons. This document remains usable whichever way the decision goes.

2. Scope

- Naming and identifiers for every account class in ACC-01 §3: staff, end user, departmental temporary-worker access, vendor, guest, service and administrative.
- User principal name, primary SMTP address, display name, mail alias and sAMAccountName where it still applies.

- The structure — not merely the string — of departmental access for temporary workers, because the two options in section 4 differ architecturally and not only in what they are called. Out of scope: group and distribution list naming, which is M365-04; SharePoint site and Teams naming, which are M365-10 and M365-07; device naming, which is DEV-01 §10.

3. Naming rules that are not in question

These are the settled conventions most tenants already follow. Record yours here so they stop being re-derived.

Account class	UPN / primary address	Display name	Notes
Staff, including part-time and contract staff	firstnamelastname@yourdomain, or an established shortened form where the full form is unavailable	Firstname Lastname	Both forms are in live use across the tenant. Neither is wrong; the rule is that one person has one primary address and it does not change on a whim.
End user (client, member, volunteer or learner)	Generated from the system of record	Firstname Lastname	Automated. IT does not hand-craft end-user identifiers. Employment status lives in directory attributes, not in the name (M365-04).
Guest, external	Retains the home-tenant address, appearing as name_domain#EXT#@yourtenant.onmicrosoft.com	Firstname Lastname (Organisation)	The #EXT# form is generated by Entra and is not ours to choose. The display name must name the organisation so staff can see at a glance who is external (ACC-10).
Service, non-human	svc-@your domain	SVC — —	The owning tier belongs in the display name because a service account with no visible owner is how orphaned automation begins (ACC-08).

Account class	UPN / primary address	Display name	Notes
Administrative, privileged	Initials + admin, e.g. jdadmin@yourtenant.onmicrosoft.com	Firstname Lastname (Admin)	Privileged identities stay on the onmicrosoft.com domain so they are visually distinct from mail-enabled staff accounts and are not mailbox-bearing (ACC-07).

One rule governs all of the above: a primary address is not changed to reflect a preference, a marriage, a nickname or a department move. Changes are made for legal-name changes and correction of error. Everything else is an alias (M365-05). The reason is that a changed primary address silently breaks external references, shared mailbox permissions, and every document that cited it.

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4. Departmental access for temporary workers — Option A and Option B

4.0 What is actually being decided

Someone who already holds an end-user account, and is then employed by a department, needs access to that department's mail, files and systems. The question is whether that access attaches to a second account or to their existing identity. It is an architectural choice, not a naming one, and the name is merely its most visible symptom.

The second-account pattern usually starts in one or two departments, IT often among them, and spreads one request at a time.

4.1 Option A — a suffixed second account (the common existing pattern)

The person keeps their end-user identity and receives an additional account for departmental work.

Element	Pattern
UPN and primary address	tmp_@yourdomain
Display name	_TMP
Departmental prefixes	One per department that uses the pattern, for example fotmp (front office) and ittmp (IT)
Typical next step	Another department asks for its own prefix
Access model	Departmental access is granted directly to the second account. Shared mailbox membership, file permissions and application roles all attach to it.
Lifecycle	Created on hire by request, disabled manually when employment ends.

What Option A genuinely does well

These are real advantages and the case for Option B has to answer them rather than ignore them.

- Separation is structural, not configured. The departmental account holds only departmental access and the end-user account holds only end-user access. No misconfigured group can grant a departmental permission to an end-user identity, because that identity is not a candidate for it.
- Actions taken in an employment capacity are attributable to a distinct principal in every log, without having to reason about what capacity someone was acting in.
- It answers a real concern cleanly: a temporary worker reading other people's records should be doing so as an employee of the organization, not as an end user.
- Ending employment does not touch the person's end-user access. Disable one account and they carry on as a client, member, volunteer or learner, with no possibility of collateral damage.
- Where it is already in place, it costs nothing to keep.

4.2 Option B — a role group on the person's single identity (recommended)

The person has one identity. Departmental access is granted by membership of a scoped, time-bounded security group.

Element	Pattern
Identity	The person's existing account. No second account is created.
Access group	ROLE--TempWorker — for example ROLE-FO-TempWorker, ROLE-HR-TempWorker
Display name	Unchanged. The person is who they are.
Attribution of departmental mail	Outbound departmental mail is sent as the departmental shared mailbox, not as the individual, so recipients see the department. Send-as is recorded in the mailbox audit log against the individual member (M365-03, ACC-14).
Access model	Every departmental entitlement attaches to the group. Granting is one membership add; revoking is one membership remove.
Lifecycle	Membership carries an end-date expiry and is re-approved each engagement period. Expiry can be automated; a second account cannot expire itself.

What Option B does better, and why it matters here specifically

- One credential, one MFA registration. Under Option A the person registers MFA twice and can lose either. Lockouts are the largest single ticket category on most desks, and end users are usually the largest group in it. Option A adds identities to precisely the population that struggles most to keep one working.
- Revocation is one action and is hard to forget. Under Option A it depends on somebody remembering a second account exists. The usual result: temporary-worker accounts added to a departmental mailbox by reply-all email, with no named owner and no expiry trigger.
- A new department needs no naming decision — only a new group. Option A requires a fresh convention conversation every time. A convention that must be re-litigated per department is not functioning as a convention.

- End-of-engagement expiry becomes automatable, because group membership can carry an expiry date and an access review. This is the single largest reduction in standing access the organization can make cheaply.
- Investigations get easier, not harder. A person's activity sits under one identity. Under Option A, an account-sharing investigation has to reason across identities to establish a pattern.

4.3 The structural objection to Option A

> **Option A accounts are orphans by construction**
>
> ACC-01 Rule 1 makes the system-of-record entry the system of record for every identity, because that is what makes dynamic group membership, licensing, reporting and automated expiry possible.
>
> A suffixed account has no system-of-record entry of its own. It cannot be dynamically grouped from system-of-record attributes, cannot be licensed or de-licensed by rule, and cannot be expired automatically at the end of the engagement. Every one of those things must be done by hand, by someone who remembers.
>
> That is not a naming problem and it is not fixed by choosing a better suffix. It is the reason the convention keeps producing the same failures — and it applies equally to every department that adopts it.

4.4 Side by side

Dimension	Option A — suffixed account	Option B — role group
Identities per temporary worker	Two, or three if they work for two departments	One
MFA registrations to maintain	Two	One
Added lockout exposure	Yes — a second credential on the population with the highest lockout rate	None
Granting access	Create account, licence, permission it, hand over credentials	Add to one group
Revoking access	Manual, and dependent on knowing the account exists	Remove from one group
End-of-engagement expiry	Manual	Automatable, with access review
Driven from the system of record	No — the account has no system-of-record entry	Yes — the person's record already exists
Licence cost	Potentially one additional per temporary worker	None
New department onboarding	Requires a naming decision each time	Requires a group

Dimension	Option A — suffixed account	Option B — role group
Structural separation of duties	Strong, by construction	Configured, by group scoping and Conditional Access
Log attribution of departmental acts	Distinct principal	Same principal; capacity evidenced by shared-mailbox and site audit logs
Effect of ending employment	Disable one account	Remove one membership
Migration cost to adopt	None where already in place	The departments using Option A, and a countable number of people
Entitlement review (ACC-17)	Reconcile two identities per person	Review one group

4.5 Where Option A remains the right answer

Not as the default, but as a named exception. A separate account is correct where a department's work carries a regulatory obligation that requires the acting principal to be distinct, such as payment card handling or health records under privacy law. Such an account should be a proper staff-class account under §3 rather than a suffixed end-user account, and the exception list should be short, explicit and reviewed annually.

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5. Recommendation

> **Adopt Option B, with Option A retained as a narrow, named exception.**
>
> The recommendation rests on one argument above all: Option A accounts cannot be driven from the system of record, so every control the organization is trying to build — automated expiry, entitlement review, dynamic licensing, coherent audit — has to be done by hand for them, forever, by someone who remembers they exist. Most desks already have the evidence that this does not happen reliably.
>
> The secondary argument is that Option A adds a second credential to the population that generates the most lockouts, where lockouts are already the largest single workload.
>
> Option A's strongest merit — structural separation of duties — is real, and Option B must answer it with disciplined group scoping, Conditional Access, and departmental send-as rather than with good intentions. Section 7 sets those requirements.

The decision belongs with executive leadership because it changes how existing temporary workers sign in. Appendix B puts the choice on one page for them.

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6. Migration path, if Option B is adopted

Written so that the decision does not have to be taken on faith about feasibility.

6.1 Before anything moves

1. Confirm that every system a temporary worker touches honours group-based access. Verify the system of record and any self-service portal specifically; if an application can only grant access to a named principal, that application is an exception and is recorded as one (ACC-16).
2. Inventory the existing suffixed accounts: how many, in which departments, holding what.
3. Create the ROLE--TempWorker groups and permission them to exactly what the suffixed accounts hold today. No more, as a matter of discipline — a migration is the easiest moment to quietly widen access.
4. Confirm departmental send-as is configured on each shared mailbox, so outbound mail still reads as the department (M365-03).

6.2 Moving one department

1. Start with IT's own Front Door technicians. The department proposing the change should carry the first disruption.
2. Add the people to the role group. Confirm access works under their own identity before removing anything.
3. Run both in parallel for one full pay period, so a failure is an inconvenience rather than an incident.
4. Disable the suffixed accounts. Do not delete — retain per ACC-01 §7.3 in case anything addressed them directly.
5. Record what broke. That list is the brief for the second department.

6.3 Completing

1. Move the next department, using the IT lessons.
2. Onboard any new department directly onto Option B, so it never acquires a suffix to unwind. That is the cheapest possible moment.
3. Add the role groups to the quarterly access review (ACC-17), with end-date expiry set.
4. Retire the suffix prefixes from this standard, leaving a note that they existed — because addresses appear in old tickets and documents and a future reader needs to know what they were.

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7. Rules that apply under either option

These are the requirements that make Option B safe, and that Option A should adopt regardless.

- Departmental access is scoped to what the role needs and nothing else. "The same as the last temporary worker had" is not a scope.
- Access expires at the end of each engagement period and is re-approved, whether or not the person still holds an end-user account and whether or not they remain employed. Those are different relationships and must expire independently (ACC-01 §6.3).
- Every departmental mailbox, site and system a temporary worker can reach has a named owner who approves the access (M365-03, M365-10).
- Outbound departmental mail is sent as the department, not the individual.
- A temporary worker never receives standing administrative rights in any system. Where elevated action is needed, it is performed by staff (ACC-07, DEV-12).

- MFA is registered before departmental access is granted, not after (ACC-03 §5.1).

8. Prohibited patterns

Do not	Because
Create an account with no record in the system of record	It cannot be grouped, licensed, expired or reviewed by rule, and becomes permanent by default (§4.3).
Change a primary address to reflect a preference or a department move	It silently breaks external references and shared permissions. Add an alias instead (M365-05).
Encode a department, job title or cohort into a person's primary address	People move. The name then lies, and correcting it breaks things.
Reuse an identifier that previously belonged to someone else	Old permissions, old mail and old references follow the string, not the person.
Create a shared human account for a team	It defeats every audit and makes credential sharing policy unenforceable (ACC-15). Use a shared mailbox with named members (M365-03).
Invent a new suffix or prefix without changing this standard	That is precisely how the current situation arose.

9. Change control for this standard

A naming standard is only worth having if deviating from it is harder than following it.

1. A new pattern, prefix or suffix requires a change to this document, approved by the Tier 4 approver named in the control block.
2. A request that cannot be met within the standard is raised as a change against ACC-02, not solved locally. Tier 2 and Tier 3 do not create a one-off pattern to close a ticket.
3. Where a department has an operational need the standard does not serve, that is useful information about the standard. Record it and review — the objective is a standard people can follow, not compliance for its own sake.

10. Records

Record	Held in	Retention
The adopted option, with date and approver	This document's revision history	Life of the standard
Named Option A exceptions and their annual review	IT governance record	3 years
Inventory of suffixed accounts at migration	Project record	Life of the migration + 2 years
Role group membership and end-of-engagement approvals	Entra + access review record	Per ACC-17

Record	Held in	Retention
Approved deviations from this standard	Change record against ACC-02	3 years

11. Related documents

ID	Title	Relationship
ACC-01	Account Lifecycle: Joiner, Mover, Leaver	Applies this standard at creation, and §6.3 at role change. Rule 1 is the basis of §4.3.
ACC-03	MFA Enrollment, Reset & Account Recovery	The doubled MFA burden under Option A, and the enrollment prerequisite in §7.
ACC-09	Temporary Worker & Departmental Access Standard	The operational detail of whichever option is adopted.
ACC-10	Guest & Sponsored External Account Standard	Guest display-name rule in §3.
ACC-16	Application Onboarding, SSO & SAML Claims Standard	Records applications that cannot honour group-based access (§6.1).
ACC-17	Periodic Access Review & Entitlement Recertification	Reviews the role groups and the Option A exception list.
M365-03	Shared Mailbox Request, Provisioning & Ownership	Departmental send-as, and the named mailbox owner §7 requires.
M365-04	Distribution List & Dynamic Group Standard	Group naming, and the system-of-record-driven membership §4.3 relies on.
M365-05	Email Alias & Address Change Standard	The alias mechanism §3 and §8 point to.

Appendix A — Naming quick reference

For Tier 2 and Tier 3 at the point of creating an account.

Creating...	Name it	First check
A staff account	firstnamelastname@yourdomain	The system-of-record entry exists (ACC-01 Rule 1)
An end-user account	Do not — it is automated from the system of record	If it is missing, the system-of-record entry is the problem
Departmental access for a temporary worker	Per the adopted option in §4 — check which is in force before creating anything	Named mailbox/site owner has approved (§7)
A guest	Do not create — request it (ACC-10)	Named sponsor, purpose and expiry

Creating...	Name it	First check
A service account	svc-@your domain, owning tier in the display name	A named human owner exists (ACC-08)
An admin account	admin@yourtenant.onmicrosoft.com	Phishing-resistant MFA registered first (ACC-07)
Anything that does not fit the above	Stop. Raise a change against ACC-02 (§9)	Do not invent a pattern to close a ticket

Appendix B — Decision matrix for executive leadership

One page. The full argument is in §4 and §5.

Question	Option A	Option B
How many accounts must a temporary worker keep working?	Two	One
Can access expire automatically at the end of the engagement?	No	Yes
Is it driven from our system of record?	No	Yes
Does adding a department need a new decision?	Yes, every time	No
Does it add to our largest support workload?	Yes — a second credential to lose	No
Additional licence cost per temporary worker	Possible	None
Separation of duties	Structural	Configured, and must be enforced
Cost to adopt	None	The departments using Option A, about one quarter
Cost of not deciding	A third department joins the pattern and the migration gets larger	—

Part of the Known Good SOP Catalog by Kevin Zelman, written for small IT shops, contractors and consultants, career-changers and help desk technicians. Adapt the names, tiers and times to your own shop: the times here are cushion, not a promise.